

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who eventually goes to hell. If Continuity and Proportionality are true, this decision must be unjust.

Could a different view of Purgatory, according to which some people in purgatory eventually go to hell, help?

Here's a possibility. Perhaps after death there are some people whose relevant properties (about which more later) make them clear choices for heaven, and some other people whose relevant properties make them clear choices for hell. The rest go to Purgatory, where they stay until they either become a clear choice for heaven or a clear choice for hell.

The result is that no one who is sent to heaven is very similar to anyone who is sent to hell. Does this solve the problem?



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
living

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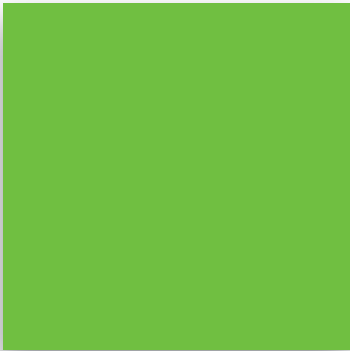
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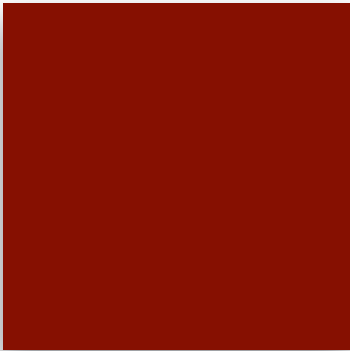












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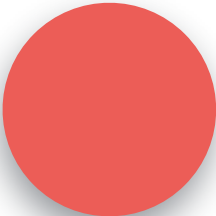
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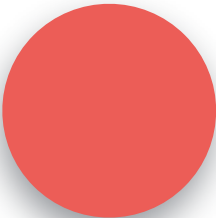






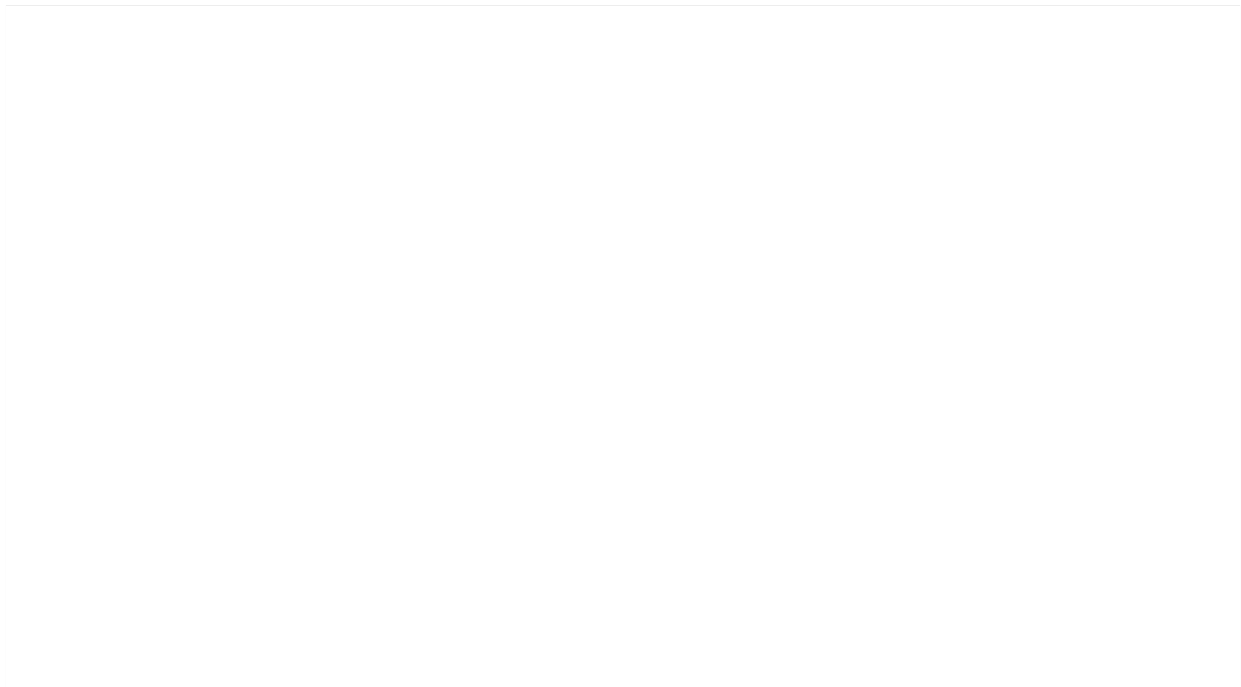
the
paradox of
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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

into external punishment, but the rights into

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

eternis in die !!

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

perfectly good Good?

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a



his glory, and all the angels with him . . .

and the wild sheep are then from another

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

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goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?







evil & lives
not worth
living

Badness

Dichotomy

Divine
control

Justice

It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



replies to the
paradox

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